

Great Awakening

Grants, Prizes & Champions

A documentary photobook on American belief systems, New Age culture, and the line between staged and real imagery. Unpublished; expected 2027 from Loose Joints.

01 Open Calls

Every grant, fellowship, prize and competition the project could be submitted to — book awards, documentary grants, portfolio and single-image competitions alike. Ranked against one project, not in the abstract: first, whether unpublished work, dummies or work-in-progress are accepted; second, whether the selector has a record with religion, belief, mysticism or American vernacular culture; third, whether it is built for documentary or long-form work. Anything closing within 60 days is flagged whatever its rank. Nothing drops off this list because it appeared last time — everything still live is still here.

BEST FIT

The strongest matches for an unpublished documentary photobook on American belief. Each takes work in progress, and none of them puts a claim on the book.

01 W. Eugene Smith Grant in Humanistic Photography

CLOSES IN 56 DAYS

NEW

W. Eugene Smith Memorial Fund · 2026 cycle

DEADLINE

12 October 2026

FEE

Verify on the call page

Deadline is 11.59pm EST on Monday 12 October 2026.

ELIGIBILITY

Open internationally. Submit a biography, project description, detailed proposal and up to 40 images. \$67,500 awarded in total: a \$30,000 main grant plus two \$10,000 finalist grants. The Howard Chapnick Grant runs on the same deadline.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The strongest fit currently open, and new to this list. It funds unfinished work outright — a proposal plus up to 40 images is exactly a book in progress — and the remit is the long-form humanistic photo essay rooted in documentary, which is criterion three almost verbatim. The fund names cultural issues alongside social and political ones, so American belief is squarely inside its brief rather than an awkward fit. At \$30,000 with no publication claim attached, it also stacks cleanly with the Loose Joints contract.

<https://www.smithfund.org/eugene-smith-grant>

02 Guggenheim Fellowship

CLOSES IN 29 DAYS

STANDING · SINCE 01

John Simon Guggenheim Memorial Foundation · 2027 United States & Canada Competition

DEADLINE

15 September 2026

FEE

None

Work samples due 29 September 2026. Late applications are not accepted.

ELIGIBILITY

Citizens and permanent residents of the US and Canada. Photography is a standing category. Aimed at applicants with a substantial record of prior achievement; there is no requirement that the proposed work be finished or published.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Still the cleanest hit on the top criterion, and now the most urgent thing on the list. The fellowship funds work in progress and asks for no published outcome, so a book a year from release is an asset rather than a disqualifier. Unrestricted money with no publisher attached, so it cannot collide with the Loose Joints contract. Photography has been a named category for decades with a long line of American documentary fellows.

<https://www.gf.org/program/how-to-apply>

03 Alicia Patterson Fellowship

CLOSES IN 45 DAYS

STANDING · SINCE 01

Alicia Patterson Foundation, administered by the Fund for Investigative Journalism · 2027 cycle

DEADLINE

1 October 2026

FEE

None

Applications submitted through the FIJ portal since the December merger.

ELIGIBILITY

US-based print and online journalists, photojournalists explicitly included. Photographers submit one set of 8 to 12 samples, published or unpublished. Two applicants may collaborate on one proposal. Six-month fellowship pays \$20,000; twelve-month pays \$40,000.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Takes unpublished photographs on its face and funds the fieldwork rather than the artefact, which is the right shape for a book still being made. American belief systems sit squarely inside "subjects of public interest", and the fellowship rewards depth over output. Like the Guggenheim it makes no claim on publication rights, so it stacks with an existing book deal instead of competing with it.

<https://aliciapatterson.org/apply/>

OPEN NOW, OR OPENING WITHIN WEEKS

Accepting entries as this issue goes out, or due to open before the next few issues are through.

04 Sony World Photography Awards 2027**NEW**

World Photography Organisation · 20th edition — Series and Single Image competitions

DEADLINE**12 January 2027****FEE**

Free

Series competition closes 12 January 2027, 1pm GMT. Single Image closes 5 January 2027. Entries have been open since 1 June 2026.

ELIGIBILITY

Open to all entrants over 18, worldwide. Series (formerly Professional) takes a cohesive series of 5 to 10 images per category; categories include Documentary Projects, Portraiture and Creative Practice. Single Image (formerly Open) takes individual frames.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Free, open now, and the first entry here that suits individual frames as well as the whole. A 5–10 image cut is a different edit from a book sequence and worth making anyway — it forces the strongest pictures to stand alone. Ranked below the grants because it pays in profile rather than production money and the jury is broad rather than specialist, but there is no cost to entering and Documentary Projects is the right category. Creative Practice is the home for anything openly constructed.

<https://www.worldphoto.org/sony-world-photography-awards>

05 The Alexia Grants**OPENS MID-SEPTEMBER****NEW**

The Alexia Foundation, Syracuse University · Professional Grant and themed strands

DEADLINE**Not yet announced****FEE**

Verify on the call page

The application window runs roughly mid-September to early October, with judging in early November and winners announced mid-November — so this opens within weeks of this issue and closes inside the 60-day horizon. Exact dates are not yet posted; set a reminder for the first week of September.

ELIGIBILITY

Photographers and visual journalists of any nationality may apply. The main Professional Grant carries \$20,000 to produce the proposed project plus Sony camera and lens. Additional themed strands and an Emerging Photographer Grant run alongside it. Applications require a synopsis, proposal and CV.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The only entry on this list whose selectors have named faith as a subject they are looking for, which is criterion two met head-on rather than inferred. It is also a production grant for a proposed project, so unfinished work is the expectation, and \$20,000 with no publication claim sits cleanly beside the Loose Joints contract. The one caveat is framing: Alexia funds visual journalism that "inspires change", so the application has to lead with what the work reveals about American belief rather than with the book as an object. Reporting on the grant's exact structure varies between secondary sources — check the figures on the site before building a budget around them.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://www.alexiafoundation.org/>

OPENING SOON

Not open yet. Dates given are the expected cycle, anchored to the previous round. Grants, fellowships, book and dummy awards, and image competitions together — diary the ones worth preparing for.

06 CatchLight Global Fellowship

NEW

CatchLight · 2027 cycle

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected to open around November 2026 and close mid-December. The 2026 round closed 15 December 2025.

ELIGIBILITY

Visual storytellers worldwide. Three fellowships of \$30,000 each, for work that functions as a tool for information, connection and transformation in a community.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Serious money for work in progress, with no publication claim — the same clean profile as the Guggenheim and Alicia Patterson. The framing is community-facing, so the application would need to lead on the communities photographed rather than on the book as an art object. That is a positioning problem, not an eligibility one.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://www.catchlight.io/how-to-apply-global-fellowship>

07 Hasselblad Foundation Photo Book Grants

STANDING · SINCE 01

Hasselblad Foundation, Gothenburg · 2027 round

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

None

Next round opens early 2027. The 2026 round closed 1 April 2026 with decisions in June.

ELIGIBILITY

Open internationally to professionals working with photography — photographers, artists, curators, researchers and writers. Applications from individuals or groups. Two grants of SEK 100,000 each.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The rare book award that pays out in production money rather than a publishing contract, which makes it one of the few that can co-fund a Loose Joints title instead of trying to replace it. Explicitly scoped to the development and publication of a photobook, so an unpublished manuscript is exactly what it is looking for. Dropped out of Best Fit this issue only because the W. Eugene Smith grant is open now and this is not.

<https://www.hasselbladfoundation.org/en/stipend/photo-book-fellowships/>

08 Magnum Foundation Counter Histories

NEW

Magnum Foundation · 2027 cycle

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

None

Cycles have typically opened in the first quarter. Confirm on the programme page.

ELIGIBILITY

International. Up to twelve grants of up to \$10,000, plus additional completion funds, for projects that creatively reframe the past to engage with questions of the present and future.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The brief — reframing the past to ask something about the present — is a good description of a project on American belief, where nineteenth-century spiritualism and present-day New Age practice are continuous rather than separate stories. Magnum Foundation also explicitly supports experimental documentary approaches, which matters for work that plays the staged against the real rather than pretending the distinction is settled.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://www.magnumfoundation.org/counter-histories>

09 World Press Photo Contest 2027

NEW

World Press Photo Foundation

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Free

Expected to close mid-January 2027. The 2026 contest closed 17 January, 13.00 CET.

ELIGIBILITY

Professional photojournalists worldwide. Three formats: Singles, Stories, and Long-Term Projects. Long-Term Projects requires 24–30 single frames on one theme, drawn from at least three different years, with a minimum of six frames shot in the most recent year.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Read the entry rules before you invest any time in this one. Long-Term Projects is the right shape and free to enter, but World Press Photo runs a strict code of ethics against staging and a verification process that requests camera-original files from finalists. A project whose subject is the line between staged and real is fine here only if the pictures themselves are found rather than directed — any constructed frame is a disqualification, not a talking point. If the work is straight documentary, enter; if any of it is made rather than observed, this is the wrong door and Sony's Creative Practice category is the right one.

<https://www.worldpressphoto.org/contest/entry-rules>

10 Dummy Award 2027

STANDING · SINCE 01

The PhotoBookMuseum, Cologne · formerly the Kassel Dummy Award

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected to open late 2026 and close late January 2027. The 2026 round closed 31 January online, with physical dummies due in Cologne mid-February.

ELIGIBILITY

Any photographer, artist or designer worldwide. Unpublished photobook projects submitted as a physical dummy. Around 50 books are shortlisted and exhibited at international photography events; one project is published by MAS.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The largest dummy award in the field and the purest hit on criteria one and three. The value here is not really the prize: a shortlisting puts the physical dummy in front of the photobook world a full year before the Loose Joints release. Note the winner's prize is publication — see the conflict note at the end of this section.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://dummyaward.org/>

11 LUMA Rencontres Dummy Book Award 2027

STANDING · SINCE 01

Les Rencontres d'Arles and LUMA Foundation

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected around May 2027. The 2026 round closed 13 May.

ELIGIBILITY

Open to any photographer or artist using photography submitting a previously unpublished dummy book. Special attention is paid to experimental and innovative forms of publishing. €25,000 production budget.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The €25,000 is a production budget rather than a contract, and the jury explicitly rewards formal invention — directly relevant to a book whose subject is the seam between the staged and the real, where the sequencing and the object are doing argumentative work. Arles is also the single best European stage for a documentary photobook.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://www.rencontres-arles.com/>

12 Images Vevey Book Award 2027/28

STANDING · SINCE 01

Festival Images Vevey, Switzerland · 7th edition

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

None

Biennial. Expected to open January 2027. The 6th edition closed 25 February 2025.

ELIGIBILITY

Professional artists and photographers, and those in training, worldwide. No age limit, no regional restriction. Must be currently working on a book project. Award ranges from CHF 10,000 for co-publishing to CHF 20,000 where Images Vevey is the exclusive publisher.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

A grant to make an unpublished book, judged on how well the publication format answers the photographic content — which is the question this project has to solve anyway. The CHF 10,000 co-publishing tier is the one that can sit alongside a signed publisher; the CHF 20,000 exclusive tier cannot.

<https://www.images.ch/en/grand-prix/>

13 Aperture Portfolio Prize 2027

STANDING · SINCE 01

Aperture, New York

DEADLINE

11 January 2027

FEE

Free to enter; entrants must be current Aperture print subscribers

Call expected to open November 2026, following the 2026 pattern.

ELIGIBILITY

Worldwide. Unpublished and ongoing bodies of work.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Free, open to work in progress, and the institution on the other end is the one most worth knowing before a documentary photobook comes out. Aperture publishes, reviews and exhibits in this exact register; an entry is cheap and the relationship compounds. Budget for the subscription requirement now so it is not a blocker in January.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://aperture.org/calls-for-entry/portfolio-prize/>

14 Photolucida Critical Mass 2027

NEW

Photolucida, Portland

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected to close early July 2027. The 2026 round closed 7 July 2026 — missed by five weeks.

ELIGIBILITY

Open to photographers at all levels worldwide. A portfolio of 10 images, reviewed by a pre-screening panel and then by up to 200 international photography professionals for the Top 200 and Top 50.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The most efficient introduction machine in American photography: one 10-image portfolio is seen by up to 200 curators, editors and publishers, which is Part 2 of this newsletter happening automatically. Book and exhibition awards sit on top of that, but the reviewer exposure is the real prize. Missed this year — put it in the diary now for early summer 2027, which lands just as the Loose Joints book is coming into view.

<https://www.photolucida.org/critical-mass/>

15 Review Santa Fe

STANDING · SINCE 01

CENTER, Santa Fe · 25th edition, 24–26 October 2026

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

The festival runs 24–26 October 2026. The next grants and awards cycle, including the Project Development Grant, is expected to close around 28 February 2027, matching the 2026 cycle.

ELIGIBILITY

The Project Development Grant funds a fine-art, reportage or documentary work-in-progress. Review Santa Fe itself is a juried portfolio review.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The Project Development Grant is written for exactly this stage of a project. The more valuable half is the review itself: three days in front of US editors, curators and publishers is champion-building as much as it is grant-seeking, and it feeds Part 2 of this newsletter directly.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://centersantafe.org/callsforentry>

16 Getty Images Editorial Photography Grant

NEW

Getty Images

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

None

Cycle dates not confirmed. Check the grants site before planning around it.

ELIGIBILITY

Awards from \$5,000 to \$15,000 for editorial photographers. Winners are invited to license work through the Getty Images catalogue — read that term against your own licensing plans and the Loose Joints agreement.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Production money for documentary work in progress, which is the right category. Ranked here rather than higher because the licensing invitation attached to the award is a real consideration for a project whose pictures are promised to a book, and because Getty's editorial remit skews to news rather than long-form cultural work.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://grants.gettyimages.com/en/grants/editorial-photography-grant>

17 APhF Dummy Award feat. Chose Commune

STANDING · SINCE 01

Athens Photo Festival · Athens Photo Festival 2027

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected late April 2027. The 2026 round closed 28 April online with physical copies postmarked by 30 April.

ELIGIBILITY

Juried competition open to unpublished photobook dummies worldwide. The winner receives a publishing contract with Chose Commune.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Straightforward on criteria one and three, and Chose Commune has real taste in this register. The prize is a contract, so the conflict note applies — worth entering for the shortlist exposure if your contract permits it.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://photofestival.gr/dummy-award/>

18 PhMuseum 2027 Photography Grant

STANDING · SINCE 01

PhMuseum, Bologna · 15th edition

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Around €25–30, tiered by entry date

Expected to close around February 2027. The 2026 edition closed 19 February.

ELIGIBILITY

Open worldwide to ongoing and unpublished projects, all genders. €10,000 in cash prizes.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Appetite for long-form documentary and no eligibility restriction. Modest money, but the shortlist gets real circulation in Europe. Note that PhMuseum's separate Women Photographers Grant is out of scope for you and has been removed from this list.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://phmuseum.com/grants>

19 Landskrona Foto & Breadfield Dummy Award 2027

STANDING · SINCE 01

Landskrona Foto and Breadfield Press, Sweden

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected around April 2027. The 2026 round closed 30 April.

ELIGIBILITY

Unpublished book projects. The winner is published by Breadfield Press and Landskrona Foto.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

A smaller field than Cologne or Arles, which makes the odds better, and Breadfield makes serious documentary books. Prize is publication, so the conflict note applies.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://www.landskronafoto.org/>

20 Encontros da Imagem Photobook Award 2027

STANDING · SINCE 01

Encontros da Imagem, Braga, Portugal · includes a Best Dummy category

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Expected around May 2027. The 2026 round closed 25 May with physical books due 15 July.

ELIGIBILITY

International. Separate categories for published photobooks and for dummies, so an unpublished project enters the dummy strand.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Useful second-tier dummy award with a festival attached. Lower prestige than Cologne or Arles, but it runs a published-book category too — which means the same project can come back here after the Loose Joints release.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://encontrosdaimagem.com/>

21 LensCulture Photobook Prize

STANDING · SINCE 01

LensCulture and Nazraeli Press · 2027 edition

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

The inaugural 2026 edition closed 12 August 2026. Watch for the 2027 call.

ELIGIBILITY

An unpublished project. No dummy required: 20–30 images, a project statement and a short biography. The winning project is designed, printed and distributed by Nazraeli Press.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

The entry requirement is unusually light — no dummy, just a sequence and a statement — which makes it the cheapest test of whether the edit reads to strangers. Prize is publication, so the conflict note applies.

<https://www.lensculture.com/photo-competitions/photobook>

22 FotoEvidence Book Award

NEW

FotoEvidence, Montpellier · 2027 cycle

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

Cycles have typically opened in the winter. Confirm on the award page.

ELIGIBILITY

Documentary photographers worldwide. The Book Award recognises work addressing a violation of human rights, a significant injustice or an assault on human dignity; the winner is published by FotoEvidence.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Listed for completeness and ranked low honestly: the remit is human-rights violation and injustice, and a project about American belief is not that unless the work turns on coercion or harm within these communities. If it does, this rises sharply. Their companion W Award is restricted to women photographers and is therefore out of scope.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://fotoevidence.com/book-award>

23 The Aftermath Project

NEW

The Aftermath Project · 2027 cycle

DEADLINE

Not yet announced

FEE

Verify on the call page

The 2026 cycle had not been confirmed at the time of writing. Their newsletter is the reliable announcement route.

ELIGIBILITY

International. One grant of \$25,000 with four finalist grants of \$5,000, for work on the aftermath of conflict. A special strand, 1492/1619 American Aftermaths, has addressed American historical reckoning.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Ranked low on the core remit — the foundation funds post-conflict recovery, and American New Age culture is not a war's aftermath. The exception is the 1492/1619 American Aftermaths strand, which is explicitly about the long consequences of American history; if that strand runs again and the work engages settler religion, revivalism or dispossession, the fit changes completely. Worth watching for that reason alone.

Date and fee taken from a secondary source — confirm on the official page before applying.

<https://theaftermathproject.org/>

NOT ELIGIBLE THIS CYCLE — CALENDAR IT

Real targets for this project, but not on this round. Listed so the timing decision gets made deliberately rather than by default.

24 Paris Photo–Aperture PhotoBook Awards

CLOSES IN 18 DAYS

STANDING · SINCE 01

NOT ELIGIBLE YET

Paris Photo and Aperture · 2026 edition

DEADLINE

4 September 2026

FEE

Tiered, with an early-bird rate that has already passed. Verify on the call page

Flagged because it closes inside 60 days, but the project is not eligible this cycle — entries must be finished, publicly available books.

ELIGIBILITY

Three categories: First PhotoBook, PhotoBook of the Year, Photography Catalog of the Year. Books must have been produced and published inside the edition's stated twelve-month window. First PhotoBook carries \$10,000.

WHY IT RANKS HERE

Here as a calendar item, not an application. This is the prize that matters most for a documentary photobook, and First PhotoBook is a one-shot category — there is exactly one debut to spend. Fix the Loose Joints publication date against the eligibility window now, because a release that slips across the cut-off decides which edition you enter and you do not get to choose twice.

<https://aperture.org/calls-for-entry/photobook-awards/>

Two things to settle before entering anything

First, the publisher clause. Several dummy awards pay out in a publishing contract — Chose Commune at Athens, MAS at Cologne, Breadfield at Landskrona, Nazraeli at LensCulture. With a 2027 Loose Joints book contracted, those may be unenterable or need the publisher's sign-off depending on your option and exclusivity terms. Read that clause once and most of this list resolves itself. The awards that carry cleanly alongside a signed publisher are the ones giving unrestricted or production money: W. Eugene Smith, the Guggenheim, Alicia Patterson, CatchLight, Hasselblad, the Images Vevey co-publishing tier, and the LUMA Rencontres production budget. Second, the staging question. Competitions rooted in photojournalism — World Press Photo above all — forbid directed or constructed pictures and will ask for camera originals. A project about the line between staged and real needs you to know which side each individual frame sits on before you submit it anywhere, because the answer decides which of these doors is open.

02 Champions

People who could credibly carry this book at release. A standing list: everyone still relevant is repeated every issue, because these are relationships to build slowly rather than leads to action once. New names each issue are badged as such. Contact routes are public and professional — institutional pages, departmental listings, public bylines.

SCHOLARS — AMERICAN RELIGION, VISUAL & MATERIAL CULTURE

Peter Manseau

STANDING · SINCE 01

Lilly Endowment Curator of American Religious History — **Smithsonian National Museum of American History**

The single closest match on the list. His book *The Apparitionists* (2017) is a full-length account of William Mumler, the Civil War spirit photographer who sold Mary Todd Lincoln a portrait of her husband's ghost — and it deliberately refuses to either endorse or debunk him. That is the exact fault line this project works: an image that is staged and sincere at once. He is also a curator, not only a writer, having built *Religion in Early America* at NMAH, so he can vouch for the book institutionally as well as in print.

CONTACT Staff page, americanhistory.si.edu

Rachel McBride Lindsey

STANDING · SINCE 01

Professor of American religious history and culture, Department of Theological Studies — **Saint Louis University**

A Communion of Shadows: Religion and Photography in Nineteenth-Century America (UNC Press, 2017) puts vernacular photography at the centre of American religious life — studio portraits tucked into Bibles, postmortem portraits with hair attached, spirit photographs, Holy Land stereographs. She reads ordinary photographs as devotional objects, which is the interpretive move this book needs someone respected to make in public. The book was built as a multimedia collaboration with MAVCOR at Yale, so she is already fluent in publishing images alongside argument.

CONTACT Faculty page, slu.edu

David Morgan

STANDING · SINCE 01

Professor of Religious Studies, with an appointment in Art, Art History and Visual Studies — **Duke University**

The field's anchor. *The Sacred Gaze* (2005) supplied the working vocabulary for how religious images do their work on viewers, and he co-edited *The Visual Culture of American Religions* (2001) with Sally Promey. A blurb or an essay from him places the book inside a scholarly conversation rather than leaving it as a picture book about odd Americans — which is the difference between a review cycle and a reading list.

CONTACT Faculty page, religiousstudies.duke.edu

Sally M. Promey

STANDING · SINCE 01

Professor of Religion and Visual Culture; Professor of American Studies; Deputy Director, Institute of Sacred Music — **Yale University**

Directs MAVCOR, the Center for the Study of Material and Visual Cultures of Religion, which is the institutional home for exactly this material and publishes a journal that takes photographic essays seriously. Co-editor with Morgan of *The Visual Culture of American Religions*. MAVCOR is a plausible venue for a project feature timed to the release, which makes her useful twice over — as an endorser and as a publishing route.

CONTACT MAVCOR, mavcor.yale.edu

Courtney Bender

STANDING · SINCE 01

Professor of Religion — Columbia University

The New Metaphysicals: Spirituality and the American Religious Imagination (Chicago, 2010) is the standing ethnography of American New Age practice — and it is notable for treating its subjects without condescension, which is the tonal problem any photographer working this material has to solve. If the book is going to be read as serious rather than arch, she is one of the few people whose endorsement settles the question.

CONTACT Department of Religion, columbia.edu

T. M. Luhrmann

NEW

Professor of Anthropology — Stanford University

New this issue, and close to the centre of the project. When God Talks Back (Knopf, 2012) is an ethnography of American evangelicals learning to hear God speak — her argument is that belief is not a proposition people accept but a skill they practise until the invisible becomes real to the senses. That is the same problem a photograph of a believer poses: whether what the camera records is performance, training or experience, and whether the distinction survives contact with the person. She writes for general readers and is widely reviewed, which makes her unusually useful at release.

CONTACT Department of Anthropology, stanford.edu

Leigh Eric Schmidt

STANDING · SINCE 01

Edward C. Mallinckrodt University Professor — Washington University in St. Louis

Restless Souls: The Making of American Spirituality traces the long American line from Transcendentalism to the spiritual-but-not-religious present — the deep history underneath contemporary New Age culture. He also writes as an essayist and reviewer for general readers, so he is one of the few scholars here who might actually review the book somewhere outside the academy.

CONTACT Faculty page, religiousstudies.wustl.edu

Kathryn Lofton

NEW

Professor of Religious Studies, American Studies and History — Yale University

New this issue. Oprah: The Gospel of an Icon (2011) and Consuming Religion (2017) argue that American spirituality is inseparable from American consumer culture — that the retreat, the crystal, the self-help paperback and the wellness brand are religious objects, not degraded versions of them. For a project photographing New Age culture, that is the argument that keeps the pictures from reading as satire. She is also a fluent public writer with reach well beyond religious studies.

CONTACT Department of Religious Studies, yale.edu

Jeffrey J. Kripal

NEW

Professor of Religion — Rice University

New this issue. Authors of the Impossible and Mutants and Mystics take the American paranormal seriously as a subject — visionaries, contactees, psychical research — without either debunking or endorsing, which is the same tightrope this book walks. He runs one of the few academic programmes willing to host that conversation openly, and he is unusually willing to write for non-academic outlets. Useful precisely where the material gets least respectable.

CONTACT Department of Religion, rice.edu

D. W. Pasulka

STANDING · SINCE 01

Professor of Religious Studies — University of North Carolina Wilmington

American Cosmic: UFOs, Religion, Technology (Oxford, 2019) argues that media and images are replacing religious institutions as the authority that tells believers what is real — which is a one-sentence description of the problem this book is photographing. She reaches well past the academy, and her audience overlaps almost exactly with the readership a book on American belief wants to find.

CONTACT Faculty page, uncw.edu

CURATORS

Clément Chéroux

STANDING · SINCE 01

Joel and Anne Ehrenkranz Chief Curator of Photography — The Museum of Modern Art, New York

Curated The Perfect Medium: Photography and the Occult (2004), still the canonical exhibition on photography as an instrument of belief, and won the Grand Prix de l'Imaginaire for the book. He has since run photography at the Centre Pompidou and SFMOMA before MoMA, so he is both the most senior name on this list and the one with the most specific prior commitment to this subject. A long shot for a first approach, but the alignment is unusually exact and worth a considered letter rather than a mailing.

CONTACT Department of Photography, moma.org

Valérie Rousseau

STANDING · SINCE 01

Curatorial Chair for Exhibitions and Senior Curator of Self-Taught Art and Art Brut — American Folk Art Museum, New York

Has curated art brut photography exhibitions (2019 and 2021) and most recently Self-Made: A Century of Inventing Artists. Her subject is visionary and vernacular American making — the homemade cosmology, the private system worked out in a garage — which is the same cultural material this project photographs from the outside. The Folk Art Museum is also a realistic exhibition partner at a scale where a first approach can actually land.

CONTACT folkartmuseum.org

Gregory J. Harris

STANDING · SINCE 01

Donald and Marilyn Keough Family Curator of Photography — High Museum of Art, Atlanta

Co-curated A Long Arc: Photography and the American South since 1845 with Sarah Kennel at VMFA — a survey that toured nationally with an Aperture catalogue. It is the recent benchmark for handling long-form American documentary as both an exhibition and a book, and the South is where a lot of American vernacular religion actually lives. He has demonstrated he can move a project from photographs to institution to publication, which is the arc this book needs.

CONTACT high.org

PHOTOBOOK CRITICS & EDITORS

David Levi Strauss

STANDING · SINCE 01

Critic and essayist; directed the graduate programme in Art Writing at the School of Visual Arts, 2007–21 — **Independent, New York**

Wrote *Photography and Belief* (David Zwirner Books, 2020), which sets out to explain why we believe photographs at all in an age when we know better — the precise theoretical question this project raises with pictures instead of argument. He holds ICP's Infinity Award for Writing and has been publishing on photography and politics since *Between the Eyes*. The most natural author for a catalogue essay or a long review.

CONTACT Published via David Zwirner Books and The Brooklyn Rail

Lesley A. Martin

STANDING · SINCE 01

Executive Director — **Printed Matter, Inc., New York**

Founded and published *The PhotoBook Review* for ten years, co-founded the Paris Photo–Aperture PhotoBook Awards, and edited more than 150 books across two decades at Aperture. There is not a more load-bearing person in American photobook publishing. Now at Printed Matter, which adds a distribution and event route on top of the editorial judgement.

CONTACT printedmatter.org

Brendan Embser

STANDING · SINCE 01

Senior editor, *Aperture* magazine — **Aperture, New York**

Edited *Aperture* monographs for Deana Lawson, Philip Montgomery, Louis Carlos Bernal, Ming Smith and Wendy Red Star — a list that shows a consistent appetite for American documentary with a metaphysical or communal charge to it. Formerly director of exhibitions at the Walther Collection, and a contributor to *The PhotoBook Review*. The realistic first point of contact at *Aperture*.

CONTACT Editorial contact via aperture.org

Emma Bowkett

NEW

Director of Photography, *FT Weekend Magazine* — **Financial Times, London**

New this issue, and the most useful commissioning editor on the list. *FT Weekend* runs long documentary photo essays at length and in a register that treats belief and subculture seriously rather than as curiosity. She also sits on photobook and grant juries across Europe — including the awards in Part 1 — so she is simultaneously a route to publication, a potential judge and a champion. For a *Loose Joints* title with European distribution, a magazine extract timed to release is one of the highest-value things to line up.

CONTACT *FT Weekend Magazine*, ft.com

Sean O'Hagan

STANDING · SINCE 01

Photography critic — The Guardian and The Observer

The only dedicated photography critic among the Guardian's regular art writers, and the most consistent reviewer of photobooks in the mainstream UK press. For a Loose Joints title — a British publisher with a European distribution footprint — he is the single highest-leverage review in the anglophone press, and he has a long record of taking American documentary projects seriously rather than exotically.

CONTACT Public byline, [theguardian.com](https://www.theguardian.com)

Next issue Thursday. This is a reminder feed, not a discovery feed: every open call still live and every champion still worth approaching is repeated in full each issue, badged Standing, so nothing important quietly falls off the desk while you are not acting on it. Genuinely new finds are badged New. Anything only leaves the list when its deadline has passed or its fit no longer holds.